

The Mayaguez Incident

When Cambodian gunmen boarded a US cargo ship two weeks after the fall of Saigon, the American response was robust. The only known engagement between US ground forces and the Khmer Rouge, the incident was also the last military action of the Vietnam War.

◀◀ BEFORE

In 1975, after decades of internal strife in Cambodia, the Khmer Rouge, led by the dictator Pol Pot, came to power.

THE CIVIL WAR

A **long and bloody civil war** intensified after the overthrow of King Norodom Sihanouk by the prime minister, General Lon Nol, and the disastrous **US incursion** into the country in 1970. The conflict ended when the communist **Khmer Rouge entered the capital city** of Phnom Penh on April 17, 1975.

On May 12, 1975, a month after the Khmer Rouge takeover in Phnom Penh, Cambodian gunboats seized an American container ship, the SS *Mayaguez*, on its way to Thailand. The Khmer Rouge claimed that the ship had violated Cambodian waters by sailing inside the 12 mile (19 km) territorial limits of the tiny, uninhabited island of Poulo Wai, 59 miles (95 km) off Cambodia's coast—the US recognized only a 3 mile (5 km) limit. Exactly how close the ship had been was later disputed.

The US branded Cambodia's move "an act of piracy." Efforts at diplomatic resolution through the People's Republic of China failed when China refused to mediate. Reminded of the capture of an American spy ship, the *Pueblo*, by North Korea in 1968, when the crew had been held hostage for 11 months, President Ford ordered a significant military response to Cambodia's action.